

COVER LETTER

Dear Ideogram Hiring Team,

Danny Kim connected me to this role, and after spending time with Ideogram 3.0 and reading about how the team thinks about creative tools, I wanted to apply with more than a resume. I want to explain what I actually think about what you're building.

Generative AI changes the creative tool problem from "how do we give people more options" to "how do we help people find their intent." The interface is no longer just a surface — it's a collaborator. The engineers building that collaborator need to think like product designers, not just systems architects. That's a description I recognize.

I've spent ten years building products where the quality of the user experience was non-negotiable. At PayPower, I secured and led end-to-end delivery of a white-label React Native prepaid Mastercard app — not just the architecture, but three successive client engagements I identified and closed myself. The pattern: get it in front of users, learn, iterate. At Aeroplan, I led the redemption eStore from initial architecture through a national consumer launch, then stayed close enough to the product to identify and secure three more engagements. Across my career, the instinct is the same: join, get close to users, build things that work, find what's missing next.

The technical depth is there: React deeply, TypeScript as a default, real-time rendering under performance pressure (Beyond MPD: 10,000+ data points at subsecond tolerance in SVG), and fullstack Node.js spanning eight years. On Python: I won't claim production Python depth I don't have, but I'm genuinely excited to ramp on it in a domain this interesting. The backend patterns transfer — typed APIs, data modeling, service design; the language is a ramp, not a wall.

I also build outside of work. tko.dev is my own — designed and built from scratch, full design system with token architecture, Framer Motion transitions, and light/dark theming. TechTank TO (next.techtankto.com) is a community platform I shipped: conversion-optimized onboarding, role-based funnels, shadcn/ui component library. Gridflow is in active development — social media scheduling app built with Next.js, Supabase, TanStack Query, and React Hook Form. These aren't experiments. They're shipped or in-progress products I own end-to-end.

What I want to add: I have a trained design sensibility — Environmental Design at OCAD, interior design before software. When I look at a generative creative tool, I'm evaluating it the same way I evaluate everything else: does this feel considered? Is the interaction honest about what it can and can't do? Does the output feel like it belongs to the person using it? That's the quality I want to bring to what you're building.

I use Claude Code and Cursor as daily accelerators. The way I work has already changed. I'm excited to work somewhere that expects that.

Looking forward to the conversation.

Tony Ko